Asian tiger keelback

Rhabdophis tigrinus

The Asian tiger keelback is a very unusual snake. It is both venomous (from its rear-fanged bite) and poisonous. Known as *yamakagashi* in Japan, the keelback absorbs toxins from its poisonous toad prey and stores it in its neck glands. When threatened, the snake arches its neck and oozes the poison as a deterrent. The female lays two to 40 eggs (average 10–14), which hatch after 30–45 days.

- 2–4 ft (0.7–1.2 m)
- 2–28 oz (60–800 g)
- Not known
- Amphibians
- E. and SE. Asia

▽ **TRANSFERRING TOXINS**
The black-banded keelback can pass on the toxins derived from toads to its offspring via the egg yolk.

Alpine black swallowtail

Papilio maackii

This large butterfly lives along forest edges and in grasslands where there are plentiful bushes. There are two broods per year, one hatching in late spring and the other in late summer. The adults survive for two weeks, feeding on nectar and gathering in crowds to mate. Eggs are laid on prickly ash and cork oak leaves—the preferred food of the caterpillars.

- 5–6 in (12–14 cm)
- Not known
- Prickly ash leaves, nectar
- E. Asia

△ **FANCY FEMALE**
The female alpine black swallowtail is more vibrantly colored than the male, with red and blue spots behind the green band that runs across both wings.

Japanese giant salamander

Andrias japonicus

This freshwater monster is the second largest amphibian on earth after the Chinese giant salamander. It breathes exclusively through its skin, which restricts it to living in cold, fast-flowing, oxygen-rich rivers. Between August and September, adults congregate at underwater nest sites to spawn. Females lay their eggs in burrows in riverbanks. These are fertilized and guarded by males until they hatch. The young remain as larvae for four to five years, and mature 10 years later.

- 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- Late summer
- Near threatened
- Fish, insects, crustaceans

E. Asia (Japan)

△ **SENSITIVE SKIN**
The salamander's tiny eyes are no use in finding prey. Instead, it uses its sense of smell and sensors in its skin that pick up water currents produced by passing prey.